

- RAG Learning

1.2 Textual Variations and Representations

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 1 Section A (3.1.1)

This section explores how texts **vary** by audience, purpose, mode, genre, time and context, and how they **represent** people, events and ideas. Paper 1 Section A gives you a pair of texts to analyse comparatively. Top-band answers explain how lexical, grammatical, graphological and pragmatic choices construct particular versions of reality and position the reader.

1.2.1 Mode — Spoken, Written, Electronic, Multimodal

Mode is the channel through which a text is produced and received. AQA distinguishes four:

Mode	Typical features	Examples
Spoken	Real-time, turn-taking, prosody, non-fluency features (er, um), deixis, ellipsis, phatic tokens.	Conversation, interview, lecture, speech.
Written	Planned, edited, paragraphed, punctuated, tends to use more complex subordination and a wider lexis.	Novel, news article, academic essay, leaflet.
Electronic / Digital	Hybrid features — written but interactional, hyperlinks, emoji, abbreviations, creative orthography, rapid turns.	Tweet, text, WhatsApp, Reddit thread, email.
Multimodal	Combines two or more modes — text + image + sound.	Advert, music video, infographic, TikTok, PowerPoint.

Do not think of modes as pure categories. A YouTube video is spoken + visual + written subtitle + chat comments. A novel is written but its cover is multimodal. Recognise *hybridity* — Crystal called internet language "netspeak": written in form, spoken in style.

Exam Tip: When you meet an unfamiliar mode (e.g. a blog comment thread), analyse it by asking: which conventional features of each mode does it borrow? which does it break? what effect does this have on audience and purpose?

1.2.2 Audience — Who is the Text For?

Every text has an imagined audience. Clues lie in *who the text assumes the reader to be*:

- **Level of lexical complexity** — simple monosyllabic Anglo-Saxon lexis for children vs Latinate abstraction for adult experts.
- **Direct address** — "you", "parents", "fellow citizens" signal presumed relationship.
- **Presumed knowledge** — does the text explain terms, or assume them?
- **Register and tone** — intimate, deferential, authoritative, playful.
- **Cultural references** — specific brands, celebrities, places signal a targeted readership.

Audience is rarely uniform. A charity leaflet may address donors *and* sympathetic non-donors *and* stakeholders. Be careful to distinguish between the **primary audience** (directly addressed) and **secondary audience** (overhearing, e.g. journalists reading a politician's speech).

1.2.3 Purpose / Function

Common categories are: **inform**, **persuade**, **entertain**, **instruct**, **express**, **phatic** (maintain relationship), **transactional** (get something done). Texts frequently combine several. A news column is informative + persuasive + entertaining.

Jakobson's six functions

Roman Jakobson's model maps every communicative act to six *orientations*:

Function	Oriented towards	Example
Referential	the world / content	Factual report: "The train leaves at 4pm."
Emotive / Expressive	the speaker	Exclamations: "I love this!"
Conative	the addressee	Commands / persuasion: "Join us today."
Phatic	the channel / social bond	"How's it going?" — purpose is connection.
Metalingual	the code / language itself	"What does 'serendipity' mean?"
Poetic	the message form	Rhymes, slogans, literary style.

1.2.4 Genre

A **genre** is a culturally recognised text type with conventional features. Readers bring genre expectations; writers exploit or subvert them.

Genre	Conventions
News report	Headline, byline, lead paragraph, inverted pyramid structure, direct quotation, third-person narration.
Recipe	Ingredient list with quantities, numbered imperative steps, cooking times, photograph.
Obituary	Chronological life summary, subject in third person, respectful register, past tense.
Advert	Strapline / headline, brand logo, image, call to action, emotive or playful lexis.
Blog post	First-person voice, direct address, hyperlinks, images, comment section, date stamp.

Genre conventions are not laws but expectations. A satirical article may adopt the form of a news report and undercut its content. That tension is itself meaningful — worth commenting on in an exam.

1.2.5 Context

Context is the situational, cultural, temporal and linguistic surround that shapes meaning. Linguists distinguish:

- **Situational context** — who is speaking/writing, to whom, where, when.
- **Cultural context** — wider norms, ideologies and shared knowledge.
- **Linguistic / co-text** — the surrounding text that shapes a word's meaning.
- **Temporal context** — the historical moment (important for 1600-present range the spec requires).

Without context, no utterance can be fully interpreted. "It's cold in here" is literal in one context, a request in another. For A-level examiners, engagement with context satisfies AO3.

1.2.6 Representation

Representation is how language constructs a version of people, events or ideas. Language is never a neutral mirror — every choice of word, grammatical structure and graphological feature positions the reader and encodes a viewpoint.

Lexical choices construct representation

Compare:

- "*Migrants*" vs "*invaders*" — same referent, radically different connotations.
- "*Freedom fighters*" vs "*terrorists*" — evaluation built into the lexis.
- "*Passed away*" vs "*died*" vs "*kicked the bucket*" — euphemism, neutral, dysphemism.

Grammatical choices construct representation

- **Active vs passive voice** — "Police shot the protester" vs "The protester was shot" vs "Shots were fired". Each re-distributes agency.

- **Nominalisation** — "There will be redundancies" turns a process into an abstract event, hiding who decides.
- **Modality** — "should", "must", "might" encode certainty, obligation, possibility.
- **Pronouns** — inclusive "we", distancing "they".

Graphology and representation

The tabloid practice of pairing a flattering photograph with a sympathetic headline (or an unflattering one with a critical headline) is a representational choice. Typography, colour and layout all encode positioning.

Applied Example: A tabloid front page: "BRITAIN INVADED — migrants flood south coast as PM dithers". Lexis ("invaded", "flood") draws on a semantic field of warfare + natural disaster. Grammar (elliptical passive "invaded", simple present "dithers") dramatises immediacy. Graphology (all caps, red banner) signals crisis. Pragmatically, the headline presupposes that migration equals invasion, positioning the reader as nationally threatened. The same event could be reported neutrally (e.g. "Asylum seekers arrive on the south coast as government considers response") — the contrast shows representation is ideological, not inevitable.

1.2.7 Power in Discourse — Fairclough

Norman Fairclough's **Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA)** treats every text as an instance of social practice. Two categories of power:

- **Instrumental power** — exerted through direct authority: law, government, institutions. Language features: imperatives, modals of obligation ("must", "shall"), formal archaic lexis, third-person impersonal. Example: a court summons.
- **Influential power** — exerted through persuasion: advertising, journalism, political rhetoric. Language features: rhetorical questions, inclusive "we", emotive lexis, direct address. Example: a political speech.

Synthetic personalisation

Fairclough coined this term for the use of intimate/inclusive language by powerful producers to create a simulated personal relationship with a mass audience. A supermarket email that opens "Hi Tom — we've saved your favourites for you" is addressing millions using first names and inclusive pronouns. It *manufactures* intimacy.

Power asymmetry and the IRF model

Sinclair and Coulthard showed that classroom discourse typically follows **Initiation** → **Response** → **Feedback**. Teacher initiates ("What's the capital of France?"), pupil responds, teacher evaluates ("Good"). The teacher controls two turns out of three — the grammatical structure enacts institutional power.

1.2.8 Halliday's Metafunctions Applied

Every text simultaneously performs three metafunctions:

1. **Ideational** — representing experience (content).
2. **Interpersonal** — enacting relationships (stance, politeness, audience positioning).
3. **Textual** — organising the message coherently (cohesion, theme/rheme, graphology).

A question to ask of any text: what does it *represent* (ideational)? how does it *position* the reader (interpersonal)? how is it *organised* (textual)? Answering all three gives a genuinely integrated analysis.

1.2.9 Method for Paper 1 Section A

A reliable paragraph structure for your comparative analysis:

1. Identify a focused **observation** — "Text A uses a semantic field of war whereas Text B uses a semantic field of partnership."
2. Quote and **label precisely** — "The evaluative adjective 'brutal' (lexis) and the imperative 'fight' (grammar/mood)..."
3. Explain the **effect on audience** and the **representation** constructed.
4. Link to **context** (mode, genre, purpose, producer's likely position).

5. Compare with the **other text** — similarity or contrast.

Exam Tip: Integrate frameworks. A single paragraph can move across lexis, grammar, graphology and pragmatics, so long as every observation is tied to the representation or positioning it creates. That's what top-band AO1 and AO3 look like.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and give an example of: **mode, multimodal, audience (primary/secondary), purpose, genre, register, context, representation, Jakobson's six functions, semantic field, connotation, synthetic personalisation, instrumental vs influential power, IRF sequence, nominalisation, modality, active vs passive voice, ideational/interpersonal/textual metafunctions.**